

MULTICULTURALISM

Multiculturalism

In **sociology**, **multiculturalism** describes the **manner in which a given society deals with cultural diversity**. Based on the underlying assumption that members of often very different cultures can coexist peacefully, multiculturalism expresses the view that **society is enriched by preserving, respecting, and even encouraging cultural diversity**.

In the area of **political philosophy**, multiculturalism refers to the ways in which **societies choose to formulate and implement official policies dealing with the equitable treatment of different cultures**.

Multiculturalism can take place on a nationwide scale or within a nation's communities. It **may occur either naturally through immigration, or artificially when jurisdictions of different cultures are combined** through legislative decree, as in the case of French and English Canada.

- **Proponents** of multiculturalism believe that **people should retain at least some features** of their traditional cultures.
- **Opponents** say that multiculturalism **threatens the social order by diminishing the identity** and influence of the predominant culture.

MULTICULTURALISM THEORIES:

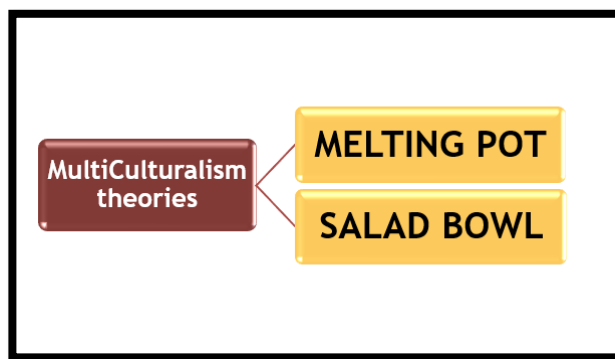
The **two primary theories or models of multiculturalism** as the manner in which different cultures are integrated into a single society are best defined by the metaphors commonly used to describe them—the **“melting pot”** and the **“salad bowl”** theories.

The Melting Pot Theory:

The melting pot theory of multiculturalism assumes **that various immigrant groups will tend to “melt together,” abandoning their individual cultures and eventually becoming fully assimilated into the predominant society**.

Typically **used to describe the assimilation of immigrants into the United States**, the melting pot theory is often illustrated by the metaphor of a foundry's smelting pots in which the elements iron and carbon are melted together to create a single, stronger metal—steel.

In 1782, French-American immigrant **J. Hector St. John de Crevecoeur** wrote that in America, “individuals of all nations are melted into a new race of men, whose labors and posterity will one day cause great changes in the world.”



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Also, **India's numerous festivals showcase this melting pot effect.** Diwali, the festival of lights, is widely celebrated across religions, becoming a symbol of national unity. Regional festivals like Onam in Kerala or Bihu in Assam add their unique flavors, enriching the national tapestry.

The **melting pot model has been criticized for reducing diversity, causing people to lose their traditions, and for having to be enforced through governmental policy.**

For example, the **U.S. Indian Reorganization Act of 1934 forced the assimilation of nearly 350,000 Indigenous peoples into American society** without any regard for the diversity of their heritages and lifestyles.

The Salad Bowl Theory:

A more **liberal theory of multiculturalism** than the melting pot, the salad **bowl theory** describes a **heterogeneous society in which people coexist but retain at least some of the unique characteristics of their traditional culture.**

Like a salad's ingredients, different cultures are brought together, but rather than coalescing into a single homogeneous culture, retain their own distinct flavors. In the United States, New York City, with its many unique ethnic communities like "Little India," "Little Odessa," and "Chinatown" is considered an example of a salad bowl society.

India's 22 official languages and countless dialects exemplify a salad bowl society. Each language carries its own cultural heritage. People can identify with their regional language while also understanding Hindi, the national language, creating a sense of unity in diversity.

The **salad bowl theory asserts that it is not necessary for people to give up their cultural heritage in order to be considered members of the dominant society.** For example, **African Americans do not need to stop observing Kwanzaa rather than Christmas in order to be considered "Americans."** Also, celebrating Diwali instead of Christmas does not diminish one's Indian identity.

On the **negative side, the cultural differences encouraged by the salad bowl model can divide a society resulting in prejudice and discrimination.** In addition, critics point to a 2007 study conducted by American political scientist Robert Putnam showing that people living in salad bowl multicultural communities were less likely to vote or volunteer for community improvement projects.

Characteristics of a Multicultural Society

Multicultural societies are **characterized by people of different races, ethnicities, and nationalities living together in the same community.** In multicultural communities, people retain, pass down, celebrate, and share their unique cultural ways of life, languages, art, traditions, and behaviors.

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The characteristics of multiculturalism often spread into the community's public schools, where curricula are crafted to introduce young people to the qualities and benefits of cultural diversity.

Though sometimes criticized as a form of “political correctness,” educational systems in multicultural societies stress the histories and traditions of minorities in classrooms and textbooks. A 2018 study conducted by the Pew Research Center found that the “post-millennial” generation of people ages 6 to 21 are the most diverse generation in American society.

Far from an exclusively American phenomenon, examples of multiculturalism are found worldwide. In **Argentina**, for example, newspaper articles, and radio and television programs are commonly presented in English, German, Italian, French, or Portuguese, as well as the country's native Spanish. Indeed, Argentina's constitution promotes immigration by recognizing the right of individuals to retain multiple citizenships from other countries.

As a key element of the country's society, **Canada** adopted multiculturalism as official policy during the premiership of Pierre Trudeau in the 1970s and 1980s. In addition, the Canadian constitution, along with laws such as the Canadian Multiculturalism Act and the Broadcasting Act of 1991, recognize the importance of multicultural diversity. According to the Canadian Library and Archives, over 200,000 people—representing at least 26 different ethnocultural groups—immigrate to Canada every year.

Why Diversity is Important

- Proponents of cultural diversity argue that it makes humanity stronger and may, in fact, be vital to its long-term survival.
- In 2001, the General Conference of UNESCO took this position when it asserted in its Universal Declaration on Cultural Diversity that “...cultural diversity is as necessary for humankind as biodiversity is for nature.”
- Today, entire countries, workplaces, and schools are increasingly made up of various cultural, racial, and ethnic groups. By recognizing and learning about these various groups, communities build trust, respect, and understanding across all cultures.
- Communities and organizations in all settings benefit from the different backgrounds, skills, experiences, and new ways of thinking that come with cultural diversity.
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Indian Constitution: Providing Multicultural Rights

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Article 14-16: Right to equality, including equality before law, prohibition of discrimination on grounds of religion, race, caste, sex or place of birth, and equality of opportunity in matters of employment.

Article 25-28: Right to **freedom of conscience and free profession**, practice, and propagation of religion.

Article 29: Right of any section of citizens to conserve their culture, language or script.

Article 30: Right of minorities to establish and administer educational institutions of their choice.